Quiz 2:

HS7.301 Science, Technology and Society

Max Marks: 30
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Bruce Bimber proposes three ways of understanding the relationship between technology and society: the normative, nomological, and unintended consequences accounts.
Using the article suggested, identify which account(s) the article tests or assumes. Based on the evidence presented, which account best explains the relationship between information technology and political participation? Explain your answer using examples from the text.
Answer in about 400–500 words.

Answer
Bruce Bimber argues that the relationship between technology and society is often explained through three different frameworks: the **normative**, **nomological**, and **unintended consequences** accounts.
The **normative account** assumes that technologies produce desirable social outcomes because they embody particular values or ideals. In the context of democratic politics, the Internet is often seen as inherently democratizing because it increases access to information and communication. According to this view, greater availability of political information should empower citizens and increase participation in democratic processes.
The **nomological account** treats technological change as producing predictable, law-like social effects. Here technology is assumed to have a direct causal impact on social behaviour. Applied to information technology, this perspective suggests that reducing the cost of acquiring political information will increase political participation. If citizens can easily obtain information about political issues and candidates, they should become more engaged in activities such as voting, campaigning, or discussing politics.
The article by Bimber primarily **tests a nomological claim** about technology and participation. The Internet is treated as a kind of "natural experiment" that dramatically increases the availability of political information while reducing its cost. If the nomological model is correct, one would expect that access to the Internet and online political information would lead to higher levels of political participation among citizens.
However, Bimber's empirical findings challenge this expectation. Using survey data from the late 1990s, he finds that access to the Internet has **little effect on traditional forms of political participation**, including voting or campaign activities. Even individuals who actively seek political information online are not significantly more likely to vote than others. The only consistent relationship observed is that Internet users are somewhat more likely to **donate money to political campaigns**.
These results suggest that technological change does not automatically produce predictable social outcomes. Instead, the findings are more consistent with the **unintended consequences account**. According to this perspective, the effects of technology emerge through complex social, institutional, and cognitive processes. Simply increasing the quantity of information available to citizens does not necessarily translate into greater political engagement. People interpret and use information in selective ways, and participation depends on many factors beyond access to information, such as political interest, social networks, and institutional structures.
Thus, while the article begins by examining a nomological theory of technological effects, its findings ultimately support the unintended consequences account. The relationship between

information technology and political participation is not straightforward or deterministic, demonstrating that the social impact of technology depends on broader political and cognitive dynamics.